

will often include shelf staples or items in the freezer, it's no biggie if a meal doesn't get made, it can just be made another day that week.

The goal of your meal plan isn't to take away spontaneity, it's to prevent those extra trips to the store to pick up something you need plus three more things you didn't. It's to prevent emergency takeout, not just at dinnertime but for breakfast and lunch. Skip the rigid plan and opt for a meal outline. You may not get excited to inventory and categorize every ingredient in your kitchen, so just create a list of options. Start with things you make often that you know you love, foods that you'd easily make before getting takeout. Consider those your pantry staples, and always have the ingredients for those things on hand, keep your freezer stocked with zero-prep meals, and commit to only one grocery store trip per week. If you want a more structured outline, try theming each day by cuisine or protein. Mondays can be Italian or meatless, Tuesdays Mexican or chicken, etc. It gives you a little guidance without feeling restricted.

If, even with a plan and a list, you're still prone to impulse spending at the grocery store, then try not going. I discovered this trick when I had my first son and he was not into grocery shopping. Ever since then, I've grocery shopped online. I quickly realized how much better I stuck to my list when I didn't go into the store. And now I do it because it saves me from *his* impulse purchases! Every Saturday before bed I head to the kitchen, identify the things that need to get used up and the things I'd like to use, and plan my meals for the week. I then buy groceries straight from my phone and pick them up Sunday afternoon. I also add things straight to my cart throughout the week as soon as I realize we're low. It has cut down on so many extra trips to the grocery store. I only have to step foot into a physical grocery store once or twice a month. It saves me time, money, and the mental energy of deciding whether to impulse buy.

I could go on about meal planning, but there's a key element that, if missed, makes your meal plan irrelevant. That key? Following through with the plan. If you don't follow through with your meal plan, then you'll spend all the money you saved, and then some, on takeout and dumping spoiled groceries in the trash. The second routine is the 20 percent effort that solves that problem 80 percent of the time.

2. Meal Prepping